

EN

Annex

European Commission Decision C(2025)7410 of 5 November 2025

European Innovation Council (EIC) Work Programme 2026

European
Innovation
Council



European Innovation Council (EIC) established by the European Commission, under the Horizon Europe programme (2021-27)

Who should read this document?

This document presents the 2026 European Innovation Council (EIC) Work Programme funded by the European Union's Horizon Europe Framework Programme for Research and Innovation. It sets out how the EIC will allocate its funding of over EUR 1.424 billion for the year 2026 and has been prepared following the advice of the EIC Board.

The Work Programme defines the calls for applications targeting innovative researchers, startups and small and medium enterprises (SMEs), scale up companies, and funders and other organisations and individuals interested in innovation. The focus is on breakthrough technologies and game-changing innovations which are high risk and with a high potential for impact and to scale up internationally and become market leaders.

A broad range of support is available, ranging from grants, investments through the EIC Fund, prizes to Business Acceleration Services (including access to coaching and mentoring, expertise and ecosystem partners). The Work Programme sets out the type of support available, how to apply, and how selection decisions are taken.

It's important for those seeking funding opportunities through the EIC to carefully read and understand the Work Programme to ensure they align with the objectives and meet the eligibility criteria as well as understand each *step* of the process.

Potential applicants, and those interested in the EIC in general, can find more information, including background to the EIC mission, organisation and practical guidance (e.g. challenge guides, frequently asked questions), on the EIC website: <https://eic.ec.europa.eu>.

Support and advice for potential applicants is available in each EU Member State and Associated Country, through **National Contact Points of Horizon Europe** (Funding & tenders (europa.eu)) and through the **Enterprise Europe Network** (<https://een.ec.europa.eu/>).

Applications can be submitted through the Funding & Tenders Portal (<https://ec.europa.eu/info/funding-tenders/opportunities/portal/screen/home>), which can also be accessed via the EIC website (<https://eic.ec.europa.eu/>).

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I. Introduction

Strategic goals and Key Performance Indicators

The EIC was established to identify, develop and scale up breakthrough technologies and companies, to achieve the green and digital transition.

The EIC Board provides strategic advice for the EIC Work Programme¹ For the period 2021-27 the EIC Board has recommended six strategic goals, with associated Key Performance Indicators (KPIs), providing clear direction, track progress, and guide implementation and potential new actions². The baselines and progress against KPI targets will be included in the annual EIC impact reports. The KPIs represent mid to long term targets.

Six Strategic Goals for the EIC:

1. To be the investor of choice for those with visionary ideas: The EIC must have continent-wide recognition and traction with high potential start-ups, entrepreneurs and innovative researchers, in particular from underrepresented groups such as women innovators and those from less developed ecosystems.
2. To crowd in EUR 30-50 billion investment into European deep tech³: The EIC must bridge a critical financing gap faced by deep tech companies and leverage the EIC Fund to influence the allocation of private assets in their support.
3. To pull through high-risk technologies in critical areas for society and open strategic autonomy: The EIC must take risks and support the most promising deep tech opportunities from the earliest stage to commercial scale-up, delivering relevant innovations for society and safeguarding against dependencies for key technologies.
4. To increase the number of European unicorns and scale ups: The EIC must support the growth and scaling up of European start-ups and SMEs to match and ultimately surpass the performance of the USA and Asia.
5. To catalyse innovation impacts from European public research and innovation: The EIC must build partnerships to draw on, and commercialise, the best ideas from the research base across the EU, and scale-up start-ups funded under other EU or national initiatives.

¹ In line with Article 12 (1) (b) Council Decision 2021/764

² European Innovation Council (EIC) Board (E03823) at <https://ec.europa.eu/transparency/expert-groups-register/screen/expert-groups?lang=en>

³ As defined in the Glossary

6. To achieve operational excellence: The agility and speed of EIC operations and decision making must align with the expectations of applicants, investors and market norms.

In addition, the EIC Board has published a set of recommendations to improve the participation of innovators from widening countries in the EIC.⁴ The recommendations are taken forward in the implementation of the EIC Work Programme, for example in the outreach activities and selection of EIC experts and jury members.

Overview of the 2026 Work Programme

The funding and support available in 2026 is organised into five main funding schemes:

1. the EIC Pathfinder for advanced research to develop the scientific basis to underpin breakthrough technologies (Section II);
2. the EIC Transition to validate technologies and develop business plans for specific applications (Section III);
3. The EIC Advance Innovation Challenges to solve demand-driven specific, ambitious societal or technological problems quickly through funding milestones (section IV)
4. the EIC Accelerator to support companies (SMEs, start-ups, spin-offs and in some cases small mid-caps) to bring their innovations to market and scale them up (Section V); and
5. the EIC Strategic Technologies for Europe Platform (STEP) Scale Up which provides high amounts of investments to scaleup companies in critical areas⁵ (SMEs, start-ups, spin-offs and small mid-caps) (Section VI).

In each case, the direct financial support for visionary researchers and innovators is complemented with access to a range of Business Acceleration Services (Section VII) providing access to leading expertise, corporates, investors and ecosystem actors.

Pathfinder, Transition and Accelerator provide for "Open" funding which can support technologies and innovations in any field without any predefined priority areas. In the case of the Pathfinder and Accelerator, this Open funding is complemented by a set of "Challenges" which target specific technologies and innovations of strategic interest for the Union. The EIC STEP Scale Up call targets technologies and innovations within the fields of digital technologies, clean and resource efficient technologies, including net-zero technologies; and biotechnologies. Outside of the

⁴ https://eic.ec.europa.eu/system/files/2023-08/EIC_Board_Statement_Widening_final31072023.pdf

⁵ Regulation - EU - 2024/795 - EN - EUR-Lex

calls, a budget is also set aside to support follow on investments to companies selected under previous EIC Work Programmes.

The Work Programme also supports a number of innovation prizes (Section VIII), and additional supporting actions allowing the functioning of the EIC such as expert contracts, data management, communication and IT (Section IX).

Linkages between these funding schemes will be maximised through proactive management (see below) and approaches, such as additional 'Booster' grants to EIC Pathfinder and EIC Transition projects (Annex 5), the Fast Track scheme to accelerate the access of successful projects from EU programmes to the EIC Accelerator (Annex 3) and the Plug in for access of projects stemming from national programmes (Annex 4).

Table 1. Summary of main calls in 2026⁶

Call	Who can apply	What for	EIC Open		EIC Challenges		
			Deadlines	Indicative Budget (EUR million)	EIC Challenge	Deadlines/ Cut-offs	Indicative Budget (EUR million)
EIC Pathfinder	Open call: only consortia can apply. Challenges call: smaller consortia (at least two eligible entities) or single applicants as well as larger consortia.	Grants up to EUR 4 million. Higher amounts if duly justified. Projects to achieve the proof of principle and validate the scientific basis of breakthrough technologies (starting from early TRLs aiming at achieving TRL3 or 4)	12/05/2026	166	II.2.1 Advanced Materials for Miniaturised Energy Harvesting Systems II.2.2 Biotechnology for Healthy Ageing II.2.3 DeepRAP: Deep Reasoning, Abstraction & Planning towards trustworthy Cognitive AI Systems	28/10/2026	96
EIC Transition	Single applicants (SMEs, spin-offs, start-ups, research organisations, universities) or small consortia (minimum 2, maximum 5 eligible entities).	Grants of up to EUR 2.5 million to validate and demonstrate technology in application-relevant environment (starting at TRL 3 achieved or 4 aiming at achieving TRL 5 or 6) and develop business and market readiness.	16/09/2026	100			
EIC Advanced Innovation Challenges	Single applicants (SMEs, spin-offs, start-ups, research organisations, universities) or small consortia (minimum 2, maximum 3 eligible entities).	First stage grants up to €0.3m to validate and benchmark potential solutions (starting at TRL 4) followed by larger grants up to €2.5m to develop, validate and user test selected solutions (aiming to reach TRL 6/7)			IV.1 Accelerating Physical AI: Embodied Intelligence for the Next Frontier of AI-Powered Robotics IV.2 Translating Disruptive New Approach Methodologies (NAMs) into Practice	26/02/2026 18/06/2027	6 in 2026; 25 in 2027 ⁷

⁶ This table provides a simplified overview. All applicants need to read the relevant sections for the full information on eligibility and conditions for funding, including Annex 2. As affiliated entities do not sign the grant agreement, they do not count towards the minimum eligibility criteria for consortium composition (if any). The Director-General responsible for the call may decide to open the calls up to one month prior to or after the envisaged date(s) of opening. The Director-General responsible may delay the call deadline(s) by up to two months.

⁷ The 2027 call will be budgeted and fully funded from EIC 2027 budget

EIC Accelerator	Single start-ups and SMEs (including spin-offs), individuals (intending to launch a start-up/ SME) and in some cases small mid-caps (fewer than 499 employees).	Grant component below EUR 2.5M for innovation activities (TRL 6 to 8) Investment component of EUR 1M up to 10 million for scaling up and other activities. Grant only and investment only component under certain conditions.	Continuous with batches 7/01/2026; 04/03/2026; 06/05/2026; 08/07/2026; 02/09/2026; 04/11/2026	414	V.2.1 Advanced Materials for Renewable Energy and Energy Storage System V.2.2 Alternative Concepts and Key Enabling Technologies for Fusion Power Plants V.2.3 Biotech for Regenerating Agricultural Soils V.2.4 Boosting the European Critical Raw Materials value chain V.2.5 Deep Tech for Climate Adaptation	Continuous with batches 7/01/2026; 04/03/2026; 06/05/2026; 08/07/2026; 02/09/2026; 04/11/2026	220
EIC- STEP Scale Up	Single startups and SMEs, small mid-caps, investors on behalf of eligible companies	Investment component of EUR 10 up to 30 million for scaling up strategic technologies for Europe.	One batch per quarter: 11/02/2026; 06/05/2026; 09/09/2026; 25/11/2026	300			

Main changes of the 2026 Work Programme

The 2026 EIC Work Programme introduces a number of changes and simplifications, following advice from the EIC Board, the mid-term review of Horizon Europe, the policy priorities of the EU in particular the Startup and Scaleup Strategy, and experience and feedback from implementation.

Main changes are

- ✦ Introduction of pilot **EIC Advance Innovation Challenges** to reinforce the risk taking and user uptake of innovations. This call will be implemented through two stages of funding, a first stage open to all applicants calls for proposed solutions to the challenge, and a second stage to be funded through a call for 2027 to select a limited number of the first stage projects to proceed to implement their solutions.
- ✦ An increase in the indicative budget size of **EIC Pathfinder** projects to €4 million to enable progress to proof-of-concept stage, along with further introduction of lump sum together with some minor improvements to the evaluation process.
- ✦ The inclusion of research results from Horizon Europe and Horizon 2020 research infrastructures as eligible for the **EIC Transition** call, alongside results from EIC Pathfinder, ERC Proof of Concept, and from Pillar 2 of Horizon Europe.
- ✦ A major simplification and shortening of the **EIC Accelerator** evaluation process with more frequent batching of proposals for evaluation and introduction of more detailed due diligence at the application stage to enable faster investment decisions.
- ✦ **Clarifications for the EIC STEP Scaleup** call, reflecting experience of implementing this call in 2025
- ✦ **Reinforced Business Acceleration Services** for internationalisation and engaging with corporates, in line with the Startup and Scaleup Strategy
- ✦ Support for a regular **Gender and Diversity Innovation index**, building on the recent pilot projects
- ✦ An update of the **Plug-In scheme**, following the completion of the pilot phase in 2023-25.

Key features of EIC support

A combination of financial and non-financial support to accelerate and grow EIC innovations and companies.

The EIC support goes far beyond funding, and it aims at supporting the emergence, acceleration and growth of EIC innovations and deep tech companies. In order to further leverage the EIC investments, all EIC Awardees will be provided with access to a range of externally contracted, bespoke Business Acceleration Services (BAS) at any stage of development of their activities. The EIC uses its pan-European reach to connect EIC Awardees with partners from all around Europe and beyond, thereby also contributing to further develop the innovation ecosystem in Europe by providing access to and from a deal flow of top-level European innovators.

EIC Awardees will also be offered facilitated or priority access to relevant research and technology infrastructures, including those hosted by the Joint Research Centre and receiving funding from Union programmes including on High Performance Computing and in-orbit demonstration and verification activities.

Proactive project and portfolio management by EIC Programme Managers

Support awarded by the EIC, and in particular by the EIC Pathfinder, is more than a one-off funding of a research project. By covering the full innovation cycle, whenever possible EIC aims to push results to higher Technology Readiness Levels (TRL). Whilst EIC Pathfinder Awardees will bear no obligation regarding the development of innovations as part of their project (beyond the evaluated proposal), the EIC will encourage and stimulate further maturation of preliminary findings and results by providing guidance as well as additional and continuous support, including financial one.

Moreover, EIC takes a proactive approach of project and programme management, performed by EIC Programme Managers,⁸ to identify, develop and implement such technology visions and to nurture potential market-creating innovations out of EIC funded projects and activities. This will include leveraging existing networks such as the European Digital Innovation Hubs. Proactive management applies to EIC Pathfinder Challenges, EIC Transition and EIC Accelerator projects and consists of the following:

- ✦ The milestones defined by the proposals for funding will be used to periodically review the progress. Reviews will assess whether the activities foreseen to reach the milestones have been completed and will consider the results and outputs against the overall objectives. The reviews will be undertaken with support of independent experts and overseen by EIC Programme Managers for projects within their portfolios.
- ✦ Following the reviews, the EIC support may be continued on the basis of its implementation according to the description of action, amendments to the grant

⁸ Appointed in accordance with point 1.2.2. of Pillar III in Annex I to Council Decision 2021/764, EIC Programme Managers are temporary staff employed by the Agency to manage one or more EIC Portfolios.

agreements may be requested or, in case a project has not met agreed milestones, it may be suspended/terminated. It can be even terminated if it has completely lost economic or technological relevance (in accordance with the grant agreement). Reviews may also result in requests for amendments to ongoing or planned activities or deployment of some necessary Business Acceleration Services (or other relevant ones, like those from EIT-KICs), including additional coaching days and access to crucial expertise. For EIC Pathfinder and EIC Transition projects, reviews may also involve an assessment to submit a proposal directly to the EIC Accelerator under the Fast Track scheme (see Annex 3) or to submit a proposal for additional Booster grants (see Annex 5). In addition to the reviews, the EIC Awardees will be expected to keep the Agency regularly informed of progress and pre-alerted in case of difficulties.

- ✦ The EIC funded projects may be included in one or more thematic or Challenge based portfolios of projects ('EIC Portfolios'), providing the projects with a productive setting in which to advance their ideas. For EIC Challenges, the portfolio will reflect the scope of the challenge ("Challenge Portfolio"). Projects to be funded through EIC Open calls may be requested to join one or more Thematic Portfolios.
- ✦ Projects selected under EIC Pathfinder Challenges will work together with Programme Managers and pursue together as a portfolio a common roadmap for the Challenge. This roadmap is prepared under the guidance of the EIC programme Manager and sets out collective activities, objectives and milestones. In order to take into account relevant changes in science and innovation or the portfolio's achievements or consistency, the objectives and roadmap of an EIC Challenge Portfolio must regularly be assessed and if necessary, revised. Based on any such revision, the Agency may request to amend the projects' activities, milestones and deliverables in accordance with the grant agreement. If a project has been selected under an EIC Challenge topic, and where no amendment can be agreed upon to ensure coherence with the updated objectives of the related Challenge Portfolio, the Agency may suspend or terminate the project in accordance with the grant agreement.
- ✦ EIC portfolio activities are identified and developed by EIC Programme Managers in consultation with the EIC Awardees of the projects in the EIC Portfolio, with relevant Commission services and where appropriate with other interested EIC Community members and third parties such as members of the innovation ecosystem. They aim at developing cooperation within an EIC Portfolio in order to achieve its objectives, enhance research, prepare transition to innovation and stimulate business opportunities understanding and enhancing of regulatory framework, and strengthen the EIC Community. Such activities may cover

participation to conferences, workshops or meetings, experience and data sharing, and participation to any relevant Business Acceleration Services events.

A tailored approach to proposal evaluation

The EIC approach to the evaluation of proposals is tailored to the objectives of each of the EIC funding schemes. For the most mature technologies, when business and market readiness levels are close to market funding, greater emphasis is put on interviews with applicants and a simplified binary scoring (GO/ NO GO).

For the EIC Pathfinder, which supports science-towards-technology breakthrough research, the evaluation follows a peer review method where proposals are evaluated, scored and ranked by experts based on weighted criteria and thresholds (see Section II).

For the EIC Transition, which funds innovation activities that go beyond the experimental proof of concept, proposals will first be evaluated remotely, scored, and ranked based on criteria and thresholds. For the top ranked applicants which are invited to the interview, the jury will decide based on a binary scoring (GO/NO GO, see Section III).

For the EIC Accelerator, which supports high risk/high gain innovations to go to the market and scale up, proposals will be evaluated remotely based on a scoring and the top ranked evaluated at interviews based on a binary scoring (GO/NO GO)⁹ (see Section V).

For the EIC STEP Scale Up, which supports promising companies developing critical technologies¹⁰, to help them secure larger funding rounds for further scaling their businesses, proposals will be evaluated following remote interview based on a binary scoring (GO/NO GO) (see Section VI).

Policy of open access and Intellectual Property rights¹¹

For the EIC Pathfinder, provisions will be applied to ensure open access to scientific publications and promote the uptake of research results (see Annex 2 on open science).

Moreover, EIC aims to stimulate the cross-fertilisation and exploitation of results from EIC supported projects. Therefore, EIC Pathfinder and EIC Transition projects may be requested at any stage by EIC Programme Managers to actively share information about results (including preliminary findings), within their EIC Portfolio and with other

⁹ In line with Article 28(3) and Article 29(2) of the Horizon Europe Regulation (Regulation (EU) 2021/695) of the European Parliament and of the Council of 28 April 2021 establishing Horizon Europe – the Framework Programme for Research and Innovation, laying down its rules for participation and dissemination, and repealing Regulations (EU) No 1290/2013 and (EU) No 1291/2013, OJ L 170, 12.5.2021, p. 1, ("Horizon Europe Regulation").

¹⁰ Regulation - EU - 2024/795 - EN - EUR-Lex (europa.eu)

¹¹ For the EIC Accelerator, the Intellectual Property rules are included in the contract and/or investment agreement.

relevant EIC projects and parties, as detailed in Annex 6. The goal is to stimulate and nurture potential innovation out of EIC Pathfinder or EIC Transition results and explore pathways to further development. This exchange of information between EIC Awardees will be without prejudice to their own legitimate interests to exploit the results or findings. To ensure full confidentiality, such sharing will be subject to non-disclosure obligations regarding confidential results, with EIC Awardees retaining the right on a case-by-case basis to fully disclose or not their intellectual property.

Technology transfer and other relevant support is expected to be provided by universities and research organisations for exploiting the results of EIC projects. In the absence of such support and without prejudice to ownership of results, the inventors of results generated by EIC Pathfinder and Transition projects may be entrusted with appropriate access rights for the purpose of further development and exploitation. Exploitation activities may be eligible to additional financial support and services offered by the EIC, as further detailed in Annex 5.

Economic security

Following the Communication on the European Economic Security Strategy¹² and the Commission Recommendation on critical technology areas for the EU's economic security¹³ a number of provisions have been made to protect Europe from economic security risks.

These measures are:

- ✦ *Eligibility criteria:* In line with Article 136 of the Financial Regulation¹⁴, in order to protect the Union's strategic assets, interests, or security also taking into account the technological objectives and expected outcomes, where necessary and duly justified, legal entities which are directly or indirectly controlled by a non-eligible third country¹⁵ or by a legal entity established in a non-eligible third country cannot participate as beneficiaries in Accelerator grant-only actions¹⁶. This restriction is exceptionally applied under the following calls:
 - specific Challenge under the EIC Accelerator related to critical raw materials (see Section V);

¹² Joint Communication by the European Commission and the High Representative of the Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy: European Economic Security Strategy, 26.06.2023, JOIN (2023) 20 final

¹³ Commission Recommendation C(2023)6689 of 3 October 2023 on critical technology areas for the EU's economic security for further risk assessment with Member States - European Commission (europa.eu)

¹⁴ EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509

¹⁵ Non-eligible third countries are countries other than countries associated to the Horizon Europe Framework Programme for the purposes of the relevant EIC actions and other countries specified in the call texts.

¹⁶ The eligibility criteria do not apply to blended finance actions and to equity-only actions because appropriate controls are implemented for the investment component in the context of the Know Your Customer (KYC) / "Red Flag" report prior to any EIC Fund investment. In addition, Investment safeguards can be introduced, where appropriate, in the investment agreements.

★ *Investment safeguards:* The inclusion of economic security safeguards provisions in investment agreements by the EIC Fund for companies selected to receive an investment component under the EIC Accelerator, in order to safeguard the Union's strategic assets, interests, autonomy, or security and to achieve technological objectives and expected outcomes for companies selected under the EIC STEP Scale Up call as well as within the four priority technology areas defined in the Commission Recommendation on critical technology areas, namely: advanced semiconductors technologies, artificial intelligence technologies, quantum technologies and biotechnologies. . The different possible safeguards are described in the EIC Fund Investment Guidelines and will be tailored to each specific investee. Where the need for such safeguard measures is identified in the Commission Award Decision, the EIC Fund will apply at least one of the safeguard measures in the investment agreement.

The requirement for investment-related measures will be introduced in the Commission Award Decision only in the case of projects (i) selected under the STEP Scale up call or falling within the four priority technology areas and (ii) involving specific technologies listed in the second column of the Annex to Commission Recommendation C(2023)6689. Moreover, the safeguard measures will only concern projects whose core purpose is to develop one of these specific technologies and not projects where these technologies are a tool or method that will be applied for a specific application, but without substantial development of the technology itself.

★ *Intellectual Property:* A requirement exists in the grant agreement for all EIC beneficiaries to inform the Agency in cases where the Intellectual Property generated by EIC projects is proposed to be transferred to an entity in a non-associated third country.

Details of the above economic security measures are provided in the call texts below.

EIC investments

The conditions concerning the list of non-cooperative jurisdictions (as amended from time to time) for tax purposes issued by the Council (OJ C 438, 19.12.2017, p. 5) (the "Council Conclusions") are applied by the EIC in respect of EIC Accelerator investments.

The EIC Fund shall not enter into any contract or maintain a business relationship with any institution or individual listed on sanction lists¹⁷, and in particular shall not make any funds available directly or indirectly to any institution or individual listed in sanction lists¹⁸.

The EIC applies the EU rules, policies and procedures, addressing the requirements in respect of money laundering, terrorism financing, tax avoidance, tax fraud, tax evasion contained in Article 158(2)(a) of the Financial Regulation¹⁹ and complies with the prohibition to enter into new or renewed operations with entities incorporated or established in jurisdictions listed under the relevant Union policy on non-cooperative jurisdictions or that are identified as high-risk third countries²⁰ or that do not effectively comply with Union or internationally agreed tax standards on transparency and exchange of information, as well as the possibility to derogate from this requirement when the action is physically implemented in one of those jurisdictions, contained in Article 158(2)(b) of the Financial Regulation²¹.

The breach of these obligations may lead to the interruption of the equity investment process.

EIC-EIT Collaboration

The EIC is progressively increasing collaboration and synergies with the EIT and its Knowledge and Innovation Communities (KICs) with the overall aim of strengthening the European Innovation Ecosystem. A number of collaboration areas are already in place and will continue to be supported under the current Work Programme facilitating the access to services to European innovators. The Fast Track process by EIT KICs, that allows proposals from companies selected by the EIT KICs to enter the EIC Accelerator evaluation at the second stage will continue; EIC beneficiaries will have access to the services provided by the EIT KICs via the partnerships agreed with the Business Acceleration Services. The “Next Generation Innovation Talents” scheme allows EIT Label Masters and Doctoral programmes, EIT Alumni, EIT Jumpstarter beneficiaries to undertake secondments in EIC and EIT supported startups and SMEs. Collaboration will

¹⁷ Consolidated list of sanctions:

https://eeas.europa.eu/headquarters/headquarters-homepage_en/8442/Consolidated%20list%20of%20sanctions

¹⁸ See Council Regulation (EU) No 833/2014 of 31 July 2014 concerning restrictive measures in view of Russia's actions destabilising the situation in Ukraine. OJ L 229, 31.7.2014, p.1. , as last amended by Council Regulation [please insert the references of the regulation on the 14th package].

¹⁹ EU Financial Regulation [2024/2509](#).

²⁰ Pursuant to Article 9(2) of Directive (EU) 2015/849 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 20 May 2015 on the prevention of the use of the financial system for the purposes of money laundering or terrorist financing, amending Regulation (EU) No 648/2012 of the European Parliament and of the Council, and repealing Directive 2005/60/EC of the European Parliament and of the Council and Commission Directive 2006/70/EC (OJ L 141, 5.6.2015, p. 73), as may be amended.

²¹ EU Financial Regulation [2024/2509](#).

continue to promote women entrepreneurs, with EIT access to the EIC Women Leadership Programme and a joint approach to the women innovator's prizes (see Section VIII).

Outlook for 2027

The EIC Work Programme for 2027 will be prepared following the advice provided by the EIC Board. It is envisaged that the main calls on Pathfinder, Transition, Accelerator and STEP will continue without major changes. The experience with the Advanced Innovation challenges call will be assessed with a view to the continuation and improvement of this support. The identification of the challenges will draw from the insights of the EIC Programme Managers and reflect the EU policy priorities and continuation of co-funding with Pillar 2. Further pilots and changes may be introduced to bridge with proposals for the future of the EIC under the successor to the Horizon Europe programme.

Subject to the adoption of the legislative changes proposed by the Commission on a defence mini-omnibus²² an amendment of the EIC Work Programme is envisaged to provide for EIC Accelerator to support to dual-use innovations and equity only investments in defence. The flagship action set out in the Startup and Scaleup Strategy²³ to launch a Scaleup Europe Fund may also require an amendment to the EIC Work Programme.

Glossary²⁴

The **Agency** entrusted by the European Commission with the implementation of Horizon Europe EIC activities, except for the EIC Fund, is the European Innovation Council and SMEs Executive Agency (EISMEA).

Deep tech²⁵ is technology that is based on cutting-edge scientific advances and discoveries and is characterised by the need to stay at the technological forefront by constant interaction with new ideas and results from the lab. Deep tech innovations are understood to be those that have the potential to deliver transformative solutions, rooted in cutting-edge science, technology and engineering, including innovation that

²² Proposal for a regulation of the European Parliament and of the Council amending Regulations (EU) 2021/694, (EU) 2021/695, (EU) 2021/697, (EU) 2021/1153, (EU) 2023/1525 and 2024/795, as regards incentivising defence-related investments in the EU budget to implement the ReArm Europe Plan

²³ "The EU Startup and Scaleup Strategy: Choose Europe to start and scale", COM(2025)270

²⁴ These definitions are complemented by specific definitions regarding provisions concerning management of EIC Portfolios and Intellectual Property for EIC Pathfinder and EIC Transition actions detailed in Annex 6.

²⁵ Deep tech ventures have the following characteristics: positioning at the knowledge frontier with long and uncertain R&I cycles; relates to tangible products and industrialisation processes; linked to the ecosystem and especially higher education institutions, problem orientated, or mission driven, focused on the creation of an option space and a dynamic de-risking cycle.

combines advances in the physical, biological and digital spheres. Deep tech is distinct from 'high tech' which tends to refer only to R&D intensity²⁶.

The **EIC Board** oversees the strategy and implementation of EIC activities and provides advice on EIC Work Programmes. It comprises 20 leading innovators and innovative researchers, as well as a full time President of the EIC Board. The EIC Board is appointed by the European Commission following an open call for expressions of interest. The EIC Board members are subject to strict rules concerning conflicts of interest and confidentiality.

The **EIC Awardees** or **EIC recipients** are the beneficiaries identified in an EIC Grant agreement (Pathfinder, Transition and Accelerator), or investees (for EIC Accelerator including EIC Step Scale Up Call), as well as winners of EIC Prizes. The Horizon Europe model grant agreements and contracts are available on the Funding and Tenders Portal²⁷.

EIC Business Acceleration Services (BAS) are support services provided to the EIC Awardees and other eligible organisations as defined in Section VII to support the innovation development of EIC project results and the commercialisation and scaling up of EIC supported innovations, including access to coaches and training, access to services of the EIC Ecosystem Partners, and access to global partners (leading corporates, investors, procurers, distributors, clients), see Section VII for more detail.

EIC business coaches are independent external experts with entrepreneurial and investment backgrounds who provide business development insights and guidance to EIC Awardees and applicants. They are part of the Business Acceleration Services.

EIC Community platform is a platform available to all EIC Awardees and Awardees of EIC Seals of Excellence²⁸, EIC Pre-Accelerator Seals of Excellence and EIC Sovereignty (STEP) Seals²⁹ and other eligible entities. It facilitates links to Business Acceleration Services as well as enabling discussions, exchanges and match making. The [EIC Community platform](#) is a virtual meeting place where EIC Awardees and all other eligible entities can access services specifically designed for EIC beneficiaries that connect them with peers, mentors and coaches, inventors, corporates, and innovation procurers. Additionally, the EIC Community platform also facilitate access the EIC Ecosystem Partners.

²⁶ Ratio of a firm's R&D investment to its revenue.

²⁷ HE Model grant agreement

²⁸ As foreseen in Article 2(23), Regulation (EU) 2021/695 establishing Horizon Europe-the Framework Programme for Research and Innovation, laying down its rules for participation and dissemination, and repealing Regulations (EU) No 1290/2013 and (EU) No 1291/2013

²⁹ As foreseen in Article 4 of Regulation (EU) 2024/795 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 29 February 2024 establishing the Strategic Technologies for Europe Platform (STEP), and amending Directive 2003/87/EC and Regulations (EU) 2021/1058, (EU) 2021/1056, (EU) 2021/1057, (EU) No 1303/2013, (EU) No 223/2014, (EU) 2021/1060, (EU) 2021/523, (EU) 2021/695, (EU) 2021/697 and (EU) 2021/241 (europa.eu)

EIC Ecosystem Partners are high quality, topic, or sector specific services from service providers from all over Europe and internationally that are not only focusing on EIC beneficiaries, that have been selected to provide Business Acceleration Services or other support to EIC Awardees, Awardees of EIC Seals of Excellence³⁰, EIC Sovereignty (STEP) Seals and EIC Pre-Accelerator Seals of Excellence and other eligible entities. EIC Ecosystem Partners can include, for example, investors, business angels, mentors and coaches, innovation agencies, business associations, clusters, accelerators, incubators, technology transfer offices, venture builders, etc. They may also include the Knowledge and Innovation Communities (KICs) of the EIT, members of the Enterprise Europe Network and Startup Europe, and the European IP Helpdesk.

EIC Expert Evaluators are external independent experts in their field who assess proposals for funding against the criteria defined in the Work Programme. The EIC expert evaluators are selected from the Funding & Tenders Portal Expert Database.

EIC expert monitors are external independent experts in their field who assist the Agency and, in some cases, EIC Programme Managers in the monitoring of projects' implementation.

EIC evaluation committees are panels of **EIC expert evaluators** who evaluate proposals and rank those that have passed the applicable thresholds. In the case of EIC Pathfinder Challenges, EIC Programme Managers participate as members in some evaluation committees as specified in the call texts.

The **EIC Fund** is an alternative investment fund (AIF) that has been established for the specific purpose of investing in companies selected through EIC Accelerator calls. An external alternative investment fund manager (AIFM, the "EIC Fund Manager") manages the EIC Fund. The European Investment Bank (EIB) supports the EIC Fund as Investment Advisor.

The **EIC Fund Manager** makes investment and divestment decisions on the companies selected through the EIC Accelerator call by following a due diligence performed by the EIB according to the EIC Investment Guidelines.³¹ The EIC Fund Manager manages the EIC portfolio of invested companies, supported by the EIB, and in close coordination with the grant support provided to investee companies by the European Commission and managed by the Agency, as well as the provision of Business Acceleration Services (including access to other potential investors via the EIC

³⁰ As foreseen in Article 2(23), Regulation (EU) 2021/695 establishing Horizon Europe-the Framework Programme for Research and Innovation, laying down its rules for participation and dissemination, and repealing Regulations (EU) No 1290/2013 and (EU) No 1291/2013

³¹ About the EIC Fund - European Commission (europea.eu)

ColInvestment Platform) and the performance of technology due diligence by the Agency.

The **EIC Forum** brings different innovation drivers and levels of governance closer together to discuss openly and informally relevant policy issues.³² The policy recommendations and activities of the EIC Forum will aim at supporting and complementing initiatives undertaken in Horizon Europe.

EIC Juries are panels of specifically selected EIC expert evaluators (including, for example, independent investors, business angels and entrepreneurs) who conduct face to face interviews with applicants to the EIC Transition, EIC Accelerator and EIC STEP Scale Up calls as part of the evaluation procedure. EIC Programme Managers and, in the case of the EIC Accelerator representatives of the EIB as Investment Adviser to the EIC Fund, may participate in jury interviews as observers, but will not be members of the jury and will not take part in the jury's decisions. **Interviews** with EIC Juries may take place in either a physical or virtual setting.

EIC Portfolio is a set of actions presenting thematic similarities (Thematic Portfolio) or contributing to the same EIC Challenge (Challenge Portfolio). Further information can be found in the proactive project and portfolio management by EIC Programme Managers section. **EIC Programme Managers** are high-level experts in specific fields of technology, business and innovation and who manage one or more **EIC Portfolios**. They are appointed to work in the Agency for a limited duration, in order to develop visions for breakthrough technologies and innovations, and to proactively manage portfolios of projects to achieve these breakthroughs. They are supported by EIC Project Officers as well as by EIC Tech to Market advisers. The EIC Programme Managers are subject to strict rules concerning conflicts of interest and confidentiality.

EIC Plug-In scheme provides that certified national or regional programmes may submit applications directly to the full application stage of the EIC Accelerator evaluation. Further details are provided in Annex 4.

EIC Tech to Market Advisers are agents employed by the Agency to assist primarily the EIC Transition projects, in agreement with EIC Programme Managers and in cooperation with EIC Project Officers, with the design and the execution of the transition plan and to facilitate access to, and follow-up of, the relevant Business Acceleration Service offerings.

EIC Project Officers are officials and other agents appointed by the Agency to manage an action.

³² The EIC Forum is supported under the 'European Innovation Ecosystems' part of the Horizon Europe work programme.

The **Enterprise Europe Network (EEN)** is a network of business intermediary organisations (chambers of commerce, technology poles, innovation support organisations, universities and research institutes, regional development organisations) that help Small and Medium-sized Enterprises (SMEs) innovate and grow internationally.

The **Innovation Radar experts** are a diverse group of professionals whose expertise lies in identifying, evaluating high-potential innovations for inclusion in the Innovation Radar platform³³, helping to determine which EU-funded research outputs have the greatest market potential and scalability.

National Contact Points (NCPs) are appointed by Member States and Associated Countries to provide guidance, practical information and assistance to applicants on all aspects of participation in Horizon Europe.

Next Generation Innovation Talents scheme supports EU funded researchers (from European Innovation Council (EIC), European Research Council (ERC), European Institute of Technology (EIT), Marie Skłodowska Curie Actions (MSCA) to carry out an innovation internship in a startup funded by the EIC or EIT. The aim is on the one hand to enable researchers and aspiring innovators to better understand and gain direct experience of real-world innovation and entrepreneurship while allowing innovative start-ups to access new ideas and insights from cutting edge of research.

Seal of Excellence: is a quality label awarded to excellent proposals which could not be funded due to lack of available budget and meeting the conditions set out in the call text, in order to facilitate access to funding from other sources³⁴. Awardees of the Seal of Excellence also have access to relevant Business Acceleration Services. Member States may decide to transfer budget from European Regional Development Fund Programmes to the Agency to fund directly Seal of Excellence proposals.

Sovereignty (STEP) Seal: is awarded to all proposals that meet the evaluation thresholds in calls contributing to the Strategic Technologies for Europe Platform (STEP). It concerns both those proposals selected for funding (to support access to complementary funding sources) and those not selected for funding due to a lack of budget (to support access to alternative funding sources). It provides access to Business Acceleration Services. For proposals not selected for funding, Member States may decide to transfer budget from European Regional Development Fund Programmes to the Agency to fund directly Sovereignty (STEP) Seal proposals.

³³ <https://innovation-radar.ec.europa.eu/>

³⁴ Information on public funding bodies that recognise and support Seal of Excellence projects is available at <https://ec.europa.eu/info/research-and-innovation/funding/funding-opportunities/seal-excellence>.

Small and Medium-sized Enterprises (SMEs) is a category of micro, small and medium-sized enterprises. It consists of enterprises that employ fewer than 250 persons and have either an annual turnover not exceeding EUR 50 million, or an annual balance sheet total not exceeding EUR 43 million. A full definition is provided in Commission Recommendation 2003/361/EC.³⁵ Under the EIC, this category includes start-ups.

Small mid-cap means an enterprise employing up to 499 employees.³⁶

Technology Readiness Levels (TRLs) provide a guide to the stage of development. TRLs are used in the Work Programme for guidance, but do not preclude support for non-technological innovations. A strong degree of importance will also be given to market readiness and business readiness,³⁷ as described in the award criteria of the call texts. The following definitions of TRLs apply, recognising that there are important differences between technological fields³⁸:

TRL1 - Basic principles observed

TRL2 - Technology concept formulated

TRL3 - Experimental proof of concept

TRL4 - Technology validated in lab

TRL5 - Technology validated in relevant environment (industrially relevant environment in the case of key enabling technologies)

TRL6 - Technology demonstrated in relevant environment (industrially relevant environment in the case of key enabling technologies)

TRL7 - System prototype demonstration in operational environment

TRL8 - System complete and qualified

TRL9 - Actual system proven in operational environment (competitive manufacturing in the case of key enabling technologies, or in space)

Women-led SMEs (including start-ups) means companies where the position of either the Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Chief Technology Officer (CTO) or Chief Scientific

³⁵ Commission Recommendation of 6 May 2003 concerning the definition of micro, small and medium-sized enterprises (2003/361/EC), OJ L 124, 20.5.2003, p. 36. and the User Guide to SME Definition: <https://op.europa.eu/en/publication-detail/-/publication/756d9260-ee54-11ea-991b-01aa75ed71a1>

³⁶ Where the staff headcount is calculated in accordance with Articles 3, 4, 5 and 6 of Title I of the Annex of Commission Recommendation 2003/361/EC.

³⁷ Further information on market readiness and business readiness will be provided in the guidance documents. ³⁸ See for instance: <https://horizon.europencpportal.eu/store/trl-assessment> and <https://euraxess.ec.europa.eu/career-development/researchers/manual-scientific-entrepreneurship/major-steps/trl>

³⁸ See for instance for health: <https://euraxess.ec.europa.eu/career-development/researchers/manual-scientific-entrepreneurship/major-steps/trl>

Officer (CSO) is held by a woman at the time of application, interview and award of the EU financial support.

Women-led consortia means consortia where the consortium coordinator is a woman and at least 50% of Work Package leaders, including the consortium coordinator, are women at the time of application, interview and award of the EU financial support.

II. EIC Pathfinder

The overall objective of the EIC Pathfinder for advanced research is to develop the scientific basis to underpin breakthrough technologies. It provides support for the earliest stages of scientific, technological or deep tech research and development. Pathfinder projects aim to build on new, cutting-edge directions in science and technology to disrupt a field and a market or create new opportunities by realising innovative technological solutions through:

- ✦ 'EIC Pathfinder Open', open to support projects in any field of science, technology or application without predefined thematic priorities.
- ✦ 'EIC Pathfinder Challenges' to support coherent portfolios of projects within predefined thematic areas with the aim to achieve specific objectives for each Challenge.

II.1 EIC Pathfinder Open

- ✦ Do you have an ambitious vision for a novel future technology that could make a real difference to our lives?
- ✦ Do you see a plausible way of achieving the scientific breakthrough that will make this technology possible?
- ✦ Can you imagine collaborating with an interdisciplinary team of researchers and innovators to validate the scientific basis of the future technology, realise a proof of principle, and explore paths to impact?

If the answer to each one of these questions is 'yes', then EIC Pathfinder Open may be the right call for you.

Why should you apply?

You should apply if you are looking for support from EIC Pathfinder Open to realise an ambitious vision for radically new technology, with potential to create new markets, respond to societal needs and/or to provide solutions for global challenges. EIC Pathfinder Open supports early-stage development of such future technologies (e.g., various activities at low Technology Readiness Levels from 1 to 4), based on high-risk/high-gain science-towards-technology breakthrough research ('deep tech'). This research must provide the foundations of the technology you are envisioning.

EIC Pathfinder Open may support your work, especially if it is highly risky: you may set out to try things that will not work; you may be faced with questions that nobody knows the answer to yet; you may realise that there are many aspects of the problem that you

do not master. On the contrary, if the approach you want to follow is incremental by nature or known, EIC Pathfinder Open will not support you.

Before applying to this call, you should verify that your proposal meets all the following essential characteristics ('Gatekeepers'):

- ✦ Convincing long-term vision of a radically new technology that has the potential to have a transformative positive effect to solving a challenge in our economy and society.
- ✦ Concrete, novel and ambitious science-towards-technology breakthrough, providing advancement towards the envisioned technology.
- ✦ High-risk/high-gain research approach and methodology, with concrete and plausible objectives.

EIC Pathfinder Open involves interdisciplinary research and development. By bringing diverse areas of research together, often with different perspectives, terminologies and methodologies, within individual projects and within a portfolio of projects, really new things can be generated, and entirely new areas of research can be opened up. It is up to you to compose the team that you need, that you can learn from, and that you can move forward with.

The expected output of your project is the proof of principle that the main ideas of the envisioned future technology are feasible, thus validating its scientific and technological basis. Project results should include top-level scientific publications in open access. While your vision is expected to be worthwhile because of its potential for future impact, for instance to create new markets, improve our lives, or provide solutions for global challenges, these are not expected to be achieved in the course of your EIC Pathfinder Open project. However, you are expected to take the necessary measures in the course of the project to allow future uptake to take place. This includes: an adequate formal protection of the generated Intellectual Property (IP)³⁹, a plan for future exploitation and an assessment of relevant aspects related to regulation, certification, and standardisation.

In addition, you are encouraged to involve and empower in your team key actors that have the potential to become future leaders in their field such as excellent early-career researchers or promising high-tech SMEs, including start-ups. Your project should reinforce their mind-set for targeted research and development aimed at high impact applied results. This will strengthen Europe's capacity for exploiting the scientific discoveries made in Europe throughout the steps to market success or for solving

³⁹ IP includes industrial property (patents, trademarks, designs and geographic indications of source) and copyright. See also Section I and Annex 6 for more information on the EIC policy of Open Access and IP rights.

global challenges. You are particularly encouraged to empower female researchers in your project and to achieve gender balance among your work package leaders.

Can you apply?

This call is open for collaborative research. Your proposal must be submitted by the coordinator, on behalf of a consortium including as beneficiaries, at least three legal entities, independent from each other and each established in a different country as follows:

- ✦ at least one legal entity established in a Member State; and
- ✦ at least two other independent legal entities, each established in different Member States or Associated Countries.

The legal entities may for example be universities, research organisations, SMEs, startups, industrial partners or natural persons.

The standard admissibility and eligibility conditions and the eligibility of applicants from third countries are detailed in Annex 2. The eligibility of associated countries and third countries is detailed in Annex 2.

Research proposals within the scope of Annex I to the Euratom Treaty, namely those directed towards nuclear energy applications, must be submitted to relevant calls under the Euratom Research and Training Programme.

Applications with elements that concern the evolution of European communication networks (5G, post-5G and other technologies linked to the evolution of European communication networks) will be subject to restriction for the protection of European communication networks (see Annex II – Section B1)

What support will you receive if your proposal is funded?

The total indicative budget for this call is EUR 166 million.

You will receive a grant for a Research and Innovation Action to cover the eligible costs, necessary for the implementation of your project. For this call, the EIC considers proposals with a requested EU contribution of up to EUR 4 million as appropriate. Nonetheless, this does not preclude you to request larger amounts, if duly justified. The funding rate of this grant will be 100% of the eligible costs.

Eligible costs will take the form of a lump sum, and the amount will be determined during the evaluation process. Applicants must therefore propose the amount of the lump sum based on their estimated project costs as defined in the Decision of 7 July 2021 authorising the use of lump sum contributions under the Horizon Europe Programme – the Framework Programme for Research and Innovation (2021-2027) –

and in actions under the Research and Training Programme of the European Atomic Energy Community (20212025).⁴⁰

In addition to funding, successful applicants will receive tailor-made access to a wide range of Business Acceleration Services (see Section [VII](#)) and interactions with EIC Programme Managers (see Section I).

Projects funded through EIC Pathfinder (including grants resulting from certain EIC pilot Pathfinder, FET-Open and Proactive calls) may be eligible:

- ✦ to receive Booster grants of a fixed amount not exceeding EUR 50 000 to undertake complementary activities to explore potential pathways to commercialisation or for portfolio activities (see Annex 5);
- ✦ to submit an EIC Transition proposal (see section III for more information about the eligibility conditions);
- ✦ to submit an EIC Accelerator proposal via the Fast Track scheme (see Annex 3);
- ✦ to participate in the 'Next Generation Innovation Talents' scheme (described in the glossary). The personnel costs of researchers participating in this scheme are eligible under your Pathfinder grants.

The Model Grant Agreement⁴¹ can be found on the EU Funding & Tenders Portal.

How do you apply; how long does it take?

The deadline for submitting your proposal is **12 May 2026 at 17h00 Brussels local time**.⁴²

You must submit your proposal via the Funding & Tenders Portal before the deadline.

Sections 1 to 3 of the part B of your proposal, corresponding respectively to the award criteria Excellence, Impact, and Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation, must consist of a maximum of 22 format A4 pages.

You will be informed about the outcome of the evaluation within 5 months from the call deadline (indicative) and, if your proposal is selected for funding, you can expect your grant agreement to be signed by 8 months after the call deadline (indicative).

⁴⁰ This decision is available on the Funding & Tenders Portal, in the reference documents section for Horizon Europe, under 'Simplified costs decisions' or through this link: https://ec.europa.eu/info/fundingtenders/opportunities/docs/2021-2027/horizon/guidance/lis-decision_he_en.pdf

⁴¹ [general-mga_horizon-euratom_en.pdf \(europa.eu\)](#), [general-mga_horizon-euratom_en.pdf \(europa.eu\)](#)

⁴² The call will open on 05 February 2026. The Director-General responsible for the call may decide to open the call up to one month prior to or after the envisaged date(s) of opening. The Director-General responsible may delay the deadline(s) by up to two months.

How does the EIC decide if your proposal will be funded?

Your proposal will be first evaluated and scored individually by at least three EIC expert evaluators with respect to the award criteria. The score for each award criterion will be the average of the evaluators' scores. The overall score from this individual evaluation phase will be the weighted sum of the three average scores from the three award criteria.

The evaluation committee, which will be composed of EIC expert evaluators different than those who evaluated the proposals individually, will decide on the final score on the basis of the score from the individual evaluation phase and the outcome of its consensus discussions.

The Evaluation Summary Report will comprise the final score, comments that summarises the assessment by the evaluation committee as well as any additional comments, possibly including advice not to resubmit the proposal.

Proposals will be assessed (Table 2) and the evaluation scores will be awarded for the criteria in accordance with the table. Each criterion will be scored out of 5. Proposals that pass the individual threshold, will be considered for funding, within the limits of the available call budget. Other proposals will be rejected.

Table 2. Award criteria for EIC Pathfinder Open
Excellence (Threshold: 4/5, weight 50%)
Long-term vision: How convincing is the vision of a radically new technology and relevant potential solutions, towards which the project would contribute in the long term?
Science-towards-technology breakthrough: How concrete, novel, and ambitious is the proposed science-towards-technology breakthrough with respect to the state-of-the-art? What advancement does it provide towards realising the envisioned technology?
Objectives: How concrete and plausible are the proposed objectives to reach the envisaged proof of principle? To what extent is the high-risk/high-gain research approach appropriate for achieving them? How sound is the proposed methodology, including the underlying concepts, models, assumptions, alternative directions and options, appropriate consideration of the gender dimension in research content, and the quality of open science practices?
Interdisciplinarity: How relevant is the interdisciplinary approach from traditionally distant disciplines for achieving the proposed breakthrough?

Impact (Threshold: 3.5/5, weight 30%)
<u>Long-term impact:</u> How significant are the potential transformative positive effects that the envisioned new technological solution would have to our economy, environment and society?
<u>Innovation potential:</u> To what extent does the envisioned new technology have potential for generating disruptive innovations in the future and for creating new markets? How adequate are the proposed measures for protection of results and any other exploitation measures to facilitate future translation of research results into innovations? How suitable
are the proposed measures for involving and empowering key actors that have the potential to take the lead in translating research into innovations in the future?
<u>Communication and Dissemination:</u> How suitable are the measures to maximise expected outcomes and impacts, including scientific publications, communication activities, for raising awareness about the project results' potential to establish new markets and/or address global challenges?
Quality and efficiency of the implementation (Threshold 3/5, weight 20%)
<u>Work plan:</u> How coherent and effective are the work plan (work packages, tasks, deliverables, milestones, timeline, etc.) and risk mitigation measures in order to achieve the project objectives?
<u>Allocation of resources:</u> How appropriate and effective is the allocation of resources (comprising person-months and other cost items) to work packages and consortium members?
<u>Quality of the consortium:</u> To what extent do all the consortium members have the necessary capacity and high-quality expertise for performing the project tasks?

For proposals with the same final score, priority will be based on the following factors, in order: higher score under the criterion Excellence; higher score under the criterion Impact; gender balance among the work package leaders as identified in the proposal; number of applicants that are SMEs; number of Member States and Associated Countries represented in the consortium; other factors related to the objectives of the call to be determined by the evaluation committee.

II.2 EIC Pathfinder Challenges

EIC Pathfinder Challenges aim to build on new, cutting-edge directions in science and technology to disrupt a field and a market or create new opportunities by realising

innovative technological solutions grounded in high-risk/high-gain research and development.

With each specific Challenge, a portfolio of projects will be established that explore different perspectives, competing approaches or complementary aspects of the Challenge. The complexity and high-risk nature of this research will require multidisciplinary collaborations.

A dedicated Programme Manager, who establishes a common roadmap and proactively steers the portfolio towards the goals of each Challenge, oversees a specific EIC Pathfinder Challenge. The projects in a Challenge portfolio are expected to interact and exchange, remaining flexible and reactive in the light of developments within the portfolio or in the relevant global scientific or industrial community. They will progress together towards common goals and create new opportunities for radical innovation.

This section refers to common criteria for all EIC Pathfinder Challenges. Please refer to the description below of each Challenge for specific information and requirements.

Why should you apply?

You should apply if you have a potential cutting-edge project proposal that would contribute to the specific objectives of the respective Challenge. Specifically, your proposed project must aim to deliver by its end the expected outcomes defined in the respective Challenge. In general, the starting point of a proposal is early TRL (e.g., 2) to up to proof of concept or validation in the lab (e.g., TRL 3 or 4). Project results should also include top-level scientific publications, adequate formal protection of the generated intellectual property (IP) as well as an assessment of relevant aspects related to regulation, certification and standardisation.

In addition, you are encouraged to involve and empower in your team key actors that have the potential to become future leaders in their fields such as excellent early-career researchers or promising high-tech SMEs, including start-ups. Your proposed project should reinforce the mind-set for targeted research and development aimed at high impact applied results. This will strengthen Europe's capacity for exploiting the scientific discoveries made in Europe throughout the steps to market success or for solving global challenges. You are particularly encouraged to empower female researchers in your project and to achieve gender balance among your work package leaders.

Before you decide to apply, you are strongly encouraged to read the respective EIC Pathfinder Challenge Guide that will be published on the EIC website and the EU Funding & Tenders Portal. The Challenge Guide will provide you with more information about the objectives of the Challenges, technical information underpinning the

objectives and portfolio considerations used for the final selection of proposals to be funded.

Can you apply?

In order to apply, your proposal must meet the general eligibility requirements (see Annex 2) as well as specific eligibility requirements for the Challenge (if applicable). Please check for particular elements (e.g., specific application focus or technology) in the respective Challenge chapter below.

The EIC Pathfinder Challenges can support projects from consortia or from single legal entities. In case of a consortium your proposal must be submitted by the coordinator on behalf of the consortium. Consortia of two entities must be comprised of independent legal entities from two different Member States or Associated Countries.

Consortia of three or more entities must include as beneficiaries at least three legal entities, independent from each other and each established in a different country as follows:

- ✦ at least one legal entity established in a Member State; and
- ✦ at least two other independent legal entities, each established in different Member States or Associated Countries.

If the proposal is from one single legal entity, this entity must be established in a Member State or an Associated Country (unless stated otherwise in the specific Challenge chapter).

The legal entities may for example be universities, research organisations, SMEs, startups, natural persons. In the case of single beneficiary projects, mid-caps and larger companies will not be permitted.

Applications with elements that concern the evolution of European communication networks (5G, post-5G and other technologies linked to the evolution of European communication networks) will be subject to restriction for the protection of European communication networks (see Annex II – Section B1).

The standard admissibility and eligibility conditions and the eligibility of applicants from third countries are detailed in Annex 2.

What support will you receive if your proposal is funded?

The total indicative budget for this call is EUR 96 million which is expected to be allocated in approximately equal shares across the Challenges.

You will receive a grant for a Research and Innovation Action to cover the eligible costs, necessary for the implementation of your project, including the portfolio activities. For

this call, the EIC considers proposals with an EU contribution of up to EUR 4 million as appropriate. Nonetheless, this does not preclude you to request larger amounts, if duly justified or stated otherwise in the specific Challenge.

The funding rate of this grant will be 100% of the eligible costs. Eligible costs will take the form of a lump sum and the amount will be determined during the evaluation process. Applicants must therefore propose the amount of the lump sum based on their estimated project costs as defined in the Decision of 7 July 2021 authorising the use of lump sum contributions under the Horizon Europe Programme – the Framework Programme for Research and Innovation (2021-2027) – and in actions under the Research and Training Programme of the European Atomic Energy Community (2021-2025).⁴³ It is advised to include a work package dedicated to portfolio activities and allocate at least 10 person-month to it.

In addition to funding, successful applicants will receive tailor-made access to a wide range of Business Acceleration Services (see Section VII) and interactions with EIC Programme Managers and other actions in the portfolio of projects selected (see Section I) to help them with the protection and exploitations of the results of the project.

Projects funded through EIC Pathfinder (including grants resulting from certain EIC pilot Pathfinder, FET-Open and Proactive calls) may be eligible:

- ✦ to receive Booster grants of a fixed amount not exceeding EUR 50 000 to undertake complementary activities to explore potential pathways to commercialisation or for portfolio activities (see Annex 5);
- ✦ to submit an EIC Transition proposal (see Section III for more information about the eligibility conditions);
- ✦ to submit an EIC Accelerator proposal via the Fast Track scheme (see Annex 3);
- ✦ to participate in the 'Next Generation Innovation Talents' scheme (described in the glossary). The personnel costs of researchers participating in this scheme are eligible under your EIC Pathfinder grant agreements.

The Model Grant Agreement can be found on the Funding & Tenders Portal.

How do you apply; how long does it take?

The call deadline for submitting your proposal is **28 October 2026 at 17h00 Brussels local time.**⁴⁴

⁴³ This decision is available on the Funding & Tenders Portal, in the reference documents section for Horizon Europe, under 'Simplified costs decisions' or through this link: https://ec.europa.eu/info/fundingtenders/opportunities/docs/2021-2027/horizon/guidance/ls-decision_he_en.pdf

⁴⁴ The call will open on 28-July-2025. The Director-General responsible for the call may decide to open the call up to one month prior to or after the envisaged date(s) of opening. The Director-General responsible may delay the deadline(s) by up to two months.

You must submit your proposal via the Funding & Tenders Portal before the deadline.

Sections 1 to 3 of the part B of your proposal, corresponding respectively to the award criteria Excellence, Impact, and Quality and Efficiency of the Implementation, must consist of a maximum of 30 format A4 pages.

You will be informed about the outcome of the evaluation by 5 months after call deadline (indicative), and, if your proposal is accepted for funding, you can expect your grant agreement to be signed by 8 months after the call deadline (indicative).

How does the EIC decide if your proposal will be funded?

After the submission of your proposal, it will be evaluated in two steps:

1. The EIC expert evaluators will assess each proposal separately against the award criteria and the EIC evaluation committee will ensure consistency across scores.
2. The EIC evaluation committee will consider all proposals passing the first step together in order to assess the best portfolio of projects to achieve the specific objectives of the Challenge (so called portfolio considerations). The evaluation committee will be composed of EIC expert evaluators and EIC Programme Managers.

Step 1 (assessment of each proposal separately):

Your proposal will be first evaluated and scored individually by at least three EIC expert evaluators with respect to the award criteria. After the individual evaluation, these evaluators will get together in a consensus group to agree on a common position on comments and scores.

After the consensus phase, the evaluation committee will check consistency across the evaluation of each individual proposal and finalise the scores and comments for all proposals.

For step 1, proposals will be assessed according to the following award criteria (Table 3).

Table 3. Award criteria for EIC Pathfinder Challenges
Excellence (Threshold: 4/5; weight 50%)
Objectives and relevance to the Challenge: How clear are the project's objectives? How relevant are they in contributing to the overall goal and the specific objectives of the Challenge?
Novelty: To what extent is the proposed work ambitious and goes beyond the state-of-the-art?

Plausibility of the methodology: How sound is the proposed methodology, including the underlying concepts, models, assumptions, appropriate consideration of the gender dimension in research content, and the quality of open science practices?

Impact (Threshold: 3.5/5; weight 30%)

Potential Impact: How credible are the pathways to achieve the expected outcomes and impacts of the Challenge? To what extent would the successful completion of the project contribute to this?

Innovation potential: How realistic is the proof of principle for demonstrating the potential impact of the technology for the challenge? How adequate are the proposed measures for protection of results and any other exploitation measures to facilitate future translation of research results into innovations with positive societal, economic or environmental impact? How suitable are the proposed measures for involving and empowering key actors that have the potential to take the lead in translating research into innovations in the future?

Communication and Dissemination: How suitable are the proposed measures, including communication activities, to maximise expected outcomes and impacts for raising awareness about the project results' potential to establish new markets and/or address global challenges?

Quality and efficiency of the implementation (Threshold 3/5; weight 20%)

Work plan: How coherent and effective are the work plan (work packages, tasks, deliverables, milestones, timeline, etc.) and risk mitigation measures in order to achieve the project objectives?

Allocation of resources: How appropriate and effective is the allocation of resources (comprising person-months and other cost items) to work packages and consortium members?

Quality of the applicant/consortium (*depends if mono or multi-beneficiaries*): To what extent does the applicant / do all consortium members have the necessary capacity and high quality expertise for performing the project tasks?

All proposals that meet the thresholds defined in the award criteria will be considered in step 2.

Step 2 (portfolio considerations):

In step 2, the evaluation committee will consider each proposal's contribution to setting up a consistent Challenge Portfolio of projects.

First, the evaluation committee will map the proposals in a number of categories stemming from the overall goal and specific objectives of the Challenge. Examples of possible categories are: building blocks or subsystems, technical areas and/or competing technologies, platforms, applications areas, risk level, stage of technology readiness level, size, etc.

Following this mapping of proposals against categories, a suitable portfolio of proposals will be selected by the evaluation committee by applying portfolio considerations in order to propose for funding a coherent set of projects that will achieve the expected outcomes and impacts of the Challenge and maximise their impact.

Further information and details about the categories and the portfolio considerations will be provided in EIC Pathfinder Challenge Guides⁴⁵, which will be topic and domain specific.

The evaluation committee may also propose some minor adjustments to the proposals as far as needed for the consistency of the portfolio approach. These adjustments will be in conformity with the conditions for participation and comply with the principle of equal treatment.

You will receive feedback in the Evaluation Summary Report which will comprise the final score and the comments endorsed by the evaluation committee as well as any additional comments. If your proposal was either retained for funding or not retained for funding while it received a score that was higher than other proposals retained for funding under the same Challenge, then you will also be informed about the underlying portfolio considerations. Comments on the detailed lump sum budget table will be provided in the Evaluation Summary Report only for proposals invited to grant agreement preparation or placed in the reserve list or rejected (possibly in part) due to significant overestimation or underestimation of costs.

What happens after a proposal is evaluated and retained for funding?

The applicant/coordinator of the proposal will receive a letter announcing the proposal has been retained for funding and the next steps regarding grant agreement signature. Grant agreement preparation and signature is expected to be completed within three months, but shorter timelines may be specified.

The EIC Project Officer and relevant EIC Programme Manager will contact applicants and provide support during the grant agreement preparation to plan the portfolio activities which y will be expected to entail collaboration between projects within the

⁴⁵ To be published in the EIC website, European Innovation Council - European Commission (europa.eu)

Challenge Portfolio, and to start the preparation of the Challenge roadmap which will define the collective deliverables, activities and objectives of the portfolio of projects selected.

During the execution of the project, you will interact continuously with the EIC Project Officer assigned to your project and the EIC Programme Manager, assigned to the Challenge Portfolio of your project, who will oversee all the portfolio projects.

II.2.1 Advanced Materials for Miniaturised Energy Harvesting Systems

Background and Scope

The exponential rise in the development and deployment of IoT (Internet of Things) systems and of connected objects (~100 billion by 2025 and ~250 billion by 2030^{46,47}) will in turn increase the number of sensor networks required to provide data on the ground, with estimates pointing to ~1Trillion by 2025 and ~10 trillion by 2040

A consequence of such an expansion is a commensurate increase in energy consumption coupled with detrimental impacts on environmental sustainability: studies point to the total electricity consumed by IoTs in 2040, equalling total global energy consumption at present. Moreover, the sensor networks, generally powered by batteries, will result in 80 million batteries having to be changed each day, with knock-on effects on the wider environment.

Mitigating the impact of a rising number of such devices calls for solutions that will reduce energy consumption and increase the energy autonomy of connected sensors such as Wireless Sensor Networks (WSN) and of the IoT systems integrating such sensors.

This Challenge therefore focuses on the development of a new generation of advanced materials ⁴⁸ to deliver miniaturised integrated energy harvesting devices, with significantly enhanced performance compared to the state of the art, that will give rise to highly effective energetically autonomous devices and systems.

This Challenge supports the ambitions of the European Commission Communication “Advanced Materials for Industrial Leadership⁴⁹”, which identified an urgent need to boost the development of advanced materials to enhance the EU’s strategic autonomy in strategic fields while addressing sustainability, circularity and safety issues.

⁴⁶ https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-981-15-5584-8_3

⁴⁷ <https://www.statista.com/statistics/471264/iot-number-of-connected-devices-worldwide/>

⁴⁸ Advanced materials are understood as materials that are rationally designed to have (i) new or enhanced properties, and/or (ii) targeted or enhanced structural features with the objective to achieve specific or improved functional performance. This includes both new emerging manufactured materials (high tech materials), and materials that are manufactured from traditional materials (low tech materials). OECD working description on advanced materials [https://one.oecd.org/document/ENV/CBC/MONO\(2022\)29/en/pdf](https://one.oecd.org/document/ENV/CBC/MONO(2022)29/en/pdf)

⁴⁹ https://research-and-innovation.ec.europa.eu/research-area/industrial-research-and-innovation/chemicals-and-advanced-materials/advanced-materials-industrial-leadership_en

Specific Objectives

Applicants to this Challenge must address all of the following objectives:

- ✦ The identification and development of innovative advanced materials for energy harvesting, harnessing new physical/ chemical phenomena, leading to a radical shift in application range and performance while reducing the reliance on Critical Raw Materials (CRMs)
- ✦ The implementation of the advanced materials in a miniaturised energy harvesting module, such as, but not limited to, miniaturised solar cells, thermoelectric generators (e.g. TEG), nanotribological/ piezoelectric devices, electromagnetic wave harvesting devices
- ✦ Integration of the miniaturised energy harvesting modules in energetically autonomous systems (e.g. wireless integrated sensors) and
- ✦ Benchmarking the harvesting modules in a representative use case in a laboratory environment (TRL 4) with a view to demonstrating significant efficiency improvements, in terms of energy harvested, compared to the state of the art.

Leveraging digital tools such as AI to accelerate the process of identifying, designing, fabricating, and characterising these new materials is encouraged.

All proposals should also identify potential markets and the associated impacts of their innovations.

Expected Outcomes

Ambitious proposals put forward under this call will:

- ✦ identify a new generation of advanced materials for miniaturised energy harvesting modules, and
- ✦ achieve TRL 4 for the resulting energetically autonomous systems.

Portfolio Approach

The portfolio of selected projects should lead to the development of a variety of advanced materials applied to a range of miniaturised energy harvesting modules and final integrated systems.

To achieve this objective, the following factors will inform the choice of projects in the portfolio:

- ✦ Phenomena exploited to harvest energy from the environment (e.g. solar, thermoelectric, piezoelectric, nanotribological etc.)
- ✦ Composition of the proposed advanced materials, and
- ✦ Field of application (e.g. agriculture, automotive, health monitoring, wearables, smart city management, energy management, industrial monitoring etc.).

The selected projects will be assigned to lead and/or engage in portfolio activities centred on the following priorities:

- ✦ benchmarking to compare proposed technologies, phenomena exploited, advanced materials used and approaches
- ✦ sharing scientific considerations, results on the different physical/chemical phenomena studied to advance the knowledge and foster new disclosures in the field with potential shifts in the paradigm
- ✦ sharing insights on integration of the modules to solve potential issues and help advance towards delivering effective operational energetically autonomous systems
- ✦ developing an integrated approach with different complimentary energy harvesting modules for specific use-cases and to enhance the final energy harvested, and
- ✦ communicating to target audiences such as corporates, investors, alongside the broader public to raise awareness on the topic with a view to accelerating the adoption of these radical innovations.

Expected Impacts

The main impacts of this Challenge will be:

- ✦ A new generation of energetically autonomous systems enabling new services that will improve the life of European citizens through applications in areas such as point of care diagnostics, smart sustainable cities etc.
- ✦ Supporting sustainability in energy consumption and production in keeping with the ambitions of RePowerEU⁵⁰ and the Green Deal⁵¹, and
- ✦ Enhancement of the sustainability of IoTs and energetically autonomous systems in general.

II.2.2 Biotechnology for Healthy Ageing

Background and Scope

Ageing, the gradual decline of organismal homeostasis and of physiologic functions throughout the body and mind, is a critical shared risk factor for many ageing-related chronic diseases. The EU also has an ageing society - by 2050, the share of 85+ year-olds in the EU is expected to more than double, but extended life expectancy is not matched with years spent in good health, which currently stands at 70.5 years. This will present significant social, economic and healthcare challenges and thus calls for interventions that will promote healthy longevity, as well as tools that will enable the adoption of these interventions.

⁵⁰ https://commission.europa.eu/topics/energy/repowereu_en

⁵¹ https://commission.europa.eu/strategy-and-policy/priorities-2019-2024/european-green-deal_en

Over the past decades basic research has identified hallmarks and cellular mechanisms of ageing, creating the basis for biotechnology-based or pharmaceutical therapeutic interventions, such as targeting cellular maintenance pathways, stem cell exhaustion, cellular senescence or metabolic fitness. Nonetheless, translating these insights into clinical interventions has had a low success rate, partially due to the difficulty of:

- ✦ Translating approaches from model systems
- ✦ Identifying when to intervene
- ✦ Rigorous validation, and
- ✦ End-to-end considerations of implementation (i.e. the delivery of an intervention).

This Challenge therefore looks to translate decades of ageing research into tangible biopharmaceutical solutions for healthy ageing

Specific Objectives

Applicants to this Challenge will be expected to develop a proof of concept in one of the following three areas:

1. **An innovative preventative or therapeutic biotechnology-based or pharmaceutical intervention** that prevents, delays or reverts the onset of a specific age-related disease. Such projects must address all of the following objectives:
 - ✦ develop an intervention that targets a fundamental molecular or cellular process of ageing, such as the hallmarks of ageing
 - ✦ assess the generalisability of the intervention (showing that it is applicable more broadly to ageing-related traits beyond the primary indication targeted) by assessing the impact of the intervention on another distinct trait related to ageing
 - ✦ demonstrate proof of concept by carrying out an interventional study in a vertebrate animal model of ageing that is physiologically aged. Projects are also encouraged to include small-scale interventional clinical studies but must at a minimum anticipate how the intervention could be feasibly tested in a clinical setting, and
 - ✦ develop a plan for exploitation, which considers ethical and societal perception, economic viability and regulatory approval. At least two of these areas, considered most relevant for the intended application, must be assessed in greater depth, suitably informing the project's technology development and contributing to the portfolio activities.

2. **A biomarker⁵² based tool** to enable the responsible deployment of ageing-related interventions, taking into consideration the following:

- ✦ The tool should be based on previously identified potential biomarker candidates or ageing clocks. All types of biomarkers are welcome, for example digital, molecular or physiological biomarkers (such as frailty measurements), combinations of biomarkers and multimodal biomarkers); as well as biomarkers for different applications (e.g. predictive, diagnostics). Biomarker discovery is explicitly excluded
- ✦ The tool should integrate different measurements of multiple molecular, anatomic, physiologic, biomechanical or biochemical traits, as appropriate, to comprehensively capture the ageing process (i.e. it should not exclusively measure a single parameter/hallmark of ageing)
- ✦ The above selected biomarker signature should enable a clear linkage between clinical features and the mechanisms of ageing to be shown
- ✦ The signature should be robust to inter-individual and intra-individual variability in ageing to provide actionable, personalised insights
- ✦ The tool should be assessed in an initial retrospective study to establish proof-of-concept. Applicants must therefore convincingly demonstrate that they have access to suitable longevity cohorts, and
- ✦ The selection of the biomarkers and the development of the tool should prioritise deployment feasibility and actively incorporate feedback from potential users.

3. **A New Approach Methodology (NAM)⁵³** that goes beyond the current state-of-the-art to enable the future development of interventions for healthy ageing. The NAM should:

- ✦ robustly capture the aged status of the system and the systemic/integrative nature of ageing (i.e. it should capture more than 1 molecular or cellular aspect of ageing, and more than 1 tissue type)
- ✦ be benchmarked against a relevant animal model of ageing, and
- ✦ be tested in the setting of a clearly specified use case (e.g. development of an intervention; as pre-clinical model in a regulatory setting).

⁵² Biomarkers are biological characteristics, which can be molecular, anatomic, physiologic, or biochemical. These characteristics can be measured and evaluated objectively. They act as indicators of a normal or a pathogenic biological process. They allow the assessment of the pharmacological response to a therapeutic intervention. A biomarker shows a specific physical trait or a measurable biologically produced change in the body that is linked to a disease or a particular health condition. A biomarker may be used to assess or detect a specific disease as early as possible (diagnostic biomarker), the risk of developing a disease (susceptibility/risk biomarker), the evolution of a disease (prognostic biomarker) – but it can also predict response to a given treatment including potential toxicity (predictive biomarker)

⁵³ New approach methodologies (NAMs) represent potential alternatives to animal testing in the non-clinical development phase of new medicines. They may include human organoids or microphysiological systems (e.g. organ-on-chip, disease-on-chip), in chemico methods, digital twins, virtual patient simulations, AI-enhanced predictive models, mechanistic or integrated in silico platforms, 3D-advanced human tissue model

Precision nutrition, the development of novel ageing clocks and wellness applications fall outside the scope of this Challenge.

All proposals should consider biological sex and gender-specific health determinants⁵⁴ in their development, with reproductive ageing also in scope.

Expected Outcomes

Ambitious proposals put forward under this call will deliver:

- ✦ Proof-of-concepts (TRL3 completed) of biotechnology-based or pharmaceutical interventions that prevents or delays the onset of, or reverts, an age-related disease in a vertebrate model system, based on the hallmarks of ageing, taking into consideration practical challenges of implementing such an intervention
- ✦ Tools to facilitate development or adoption of the interventions above, such as proof-of-concept validation of biomarker signatures or suitable pre-clinical models, and
- ✦ Approaches to address the shared regulatory hurdles and societal challenges linked to ageing-related interventions, thereby facilitating their adoption.

Portfolio approach

The portfolio of projects selected under this Challenge will ensure a coverage of projects developing interventions, biomarkers and NAMs, considering the following guidelines for portfolio composition:

- ✦ Interventions: no more than 5 projects. The portfolio of selected projects should collectively address a variety molecular and cellular processes related to ageing, and a variety of different age-related diseases.
- ✦ Biomarkers: no more than 3 projects. Projects will be selected to capture different application areas (diagnostic, predictive, prognostic biomarker), with preference to the inclusion of at least one diagnostic biomarker).
- ✦ NAMs: No more than 2 projects. Projects will be selected to capture a diversity of approaches to assess aged status in NAMs, different tissues or cell types and different use cases.

The selected consortia will benefit from mutual learning, and the exchange of expertise. Consortia will be encouraged to collaborate to address the following shared challenges faced by all ageing interventions:

- ✦ Scientific: preclinical models; Biomarkers of healthy/unhealthy ageing
- ✦ Path to Market: Defining suitable regulatory pathways, and

⁵⁴ Sex: Refers to biological characteristics (including genetic, hormonal, physiological, anatomical) that distinguish between male, female, and intersex (in humans) or hermaphrodite (in non-human animals). Gender: Refers to socio-cultural norms, identities and relations that, together, shape and sanction what are considered “feminine” and “masculine” behaviours, and structure societies and organisations. From Gender In EU Research and Innovation (https://rea.ec.europa.eu/gender-eu-research-and-innovation_en)

- ✦ Societal: Acceptance and role of preventative / therapeutic interventions, Need for improved longevity literacy.

Expected Impacts

This Challenge looks to accelerate the development and uptake of clinically validated interventions that target the root cause of multiple age-related morbidities. It will:

- ✦ Deliver biotechnology-based interventions for healthy ageing
- ✦ Accelerate the implementation of personalised care in ageing based on molecular phenotyping
- ✦ Provide recommendations for regulatory pathways addressing ageing as a target to inform developers, regulators, and other decision makers, and
- ✦ Improve citizen literacy on longevity.

II.2.3 DeepRAP: Deep Reasoning, Abstraction & Planning towards trustworthy Cognitive AI Systems

Background and Scope

Artificial Intelligence (AI) systems have achieved remarkable progress as evidenced by the ability of Generative AI to recognise patterns and generate contextually relevant outputs based on ever larger models and associated datasets. However, despite the remarkable strides made over the past decade, there remains a significant gap between the capabilities of the human brain and machine intelligence, which must be overcome to achieve robust performance and enable effective interactions with users and stakeholders.

Current Generative AI models can release very accurate outputs and even solve some mathematical problems but might struggle with some complex reasoning benchmarks and to understand the real world. These models frequently fail to reliably solve logic tasks and long-term planning, even when provably correct solutions exist, limiting their effectiveness in critical applications where precision is essential.

Inspired by the human brain's ability to process information at multiple levels of abstraction—enabling perception, reasoning, and goal-directed planning—the goal of this Challenge is to move beyond the current state-of-the-art in traditional AI approaches, whether symbolic (e.g., rules, decision trees, symbolic regression, etc.) or connectionist, neural (e.g., deep learning, large language models, reinforcement learning). The goal is to significantly improve the Reasoning, Abstraction, and Planning (RAP) capabilities of AI systems.

This will overcome the limitations of current deep learning models, which despite their strengths, have limitations in critical cognitive functions for abstraction,

contextualisation, causality, explainability, and intelligible reasoning — competencies that are fundamental to move towards human-like intelligence.

Specific Objectives

Innovative ideas put forward under this Challenge must explore novel approaches, including combinations of existing techniques (i.e. neuro-symbolic AI), or the creation of entirely new frameworks that go beyond current, traditional, deep learning and reinforcement learning paradigms. These could be inspired by developments in diverse fields such as neuroscience, biology, physics, philosophy and more.

The proposals should address one or more of the following cognitive capabilities:

1. **Deep Reasoning:** Moving beyond statistical pattern matching to support causal inference, logical reasoning, and context-aware or commonsense decision-making in complex, unstructured environments. This requires shifting from purely data-driven correlations to AI systems capable of understanding why patterns emerge, identifying underlying causes, and drawing valid conclusions through both deductive and inductive processes. Neuro-symbolic approaches, which combine the learning power of neural networks with the structured inference of symbolic reasoning are particularly encouraged to advance these capabilities. Integrating contextual and commonsense knowledge enables AI to interpret information more holistically, adapt decisions dynamically, and handle ambiguity and uncertainty. Deep reasoning systems should be able to reconcile multiple sources of information, provide transparent and explainable rationales for their outputs, and align with human values and expectations, ensuring trustworthy and accountable operations in demanding real-world scenarios.
2. **Deep Abstraction:** Enabling AI systems to generalise insights from limited data by forming, manipulating, and refining high-level concepts, analogies, and representations that can be transferred across diverse application domains. This includes the development of internal world models to support abstraction, foster commonsense understanding, and integrate semantic and contextual awareness. Approaches that combine symbolic reasoning, analogical mapping, and representation learning are particularly encouraged, as they empower AI to interpret meaning, intent, and relationships within complex environments. Progress in deep abstraction is essential for achieving cognitive flexibility, robust transfer learning, and adaptive reasoning in dynamic, data-scarce, or rapidly evolving settings.
3. **Deep Planning:** Developing robust, adaptive, and scalable planning algorithms/models capable of operating in open-world, agentic, or uncertain real-time environments. This involves leveraging advanced deep learning techniques such as deep reinforcement learning and architectures tailored for planning tasks to enable AI systems to autonomously devise, optimise, and adjust complex strategies

in dynamic settings. Neuro-symbolic approaches integrating neural networks with symbolic reasoning are particularly encouraged to address uncertainty, provide formal guarantees, and enable explainable, dependable decision-making. Emphasis is placed on long-term, flexible planning that incorporates cognitive timing and predictive modelling, enabling systems to anticipate and adapt within dynamic contexts. Approaches should explore hierarchical planning across multiple temporal levels, contingency planning for effective fallback strategies, and continual re-planning to dynamically update plans as environments evolve. These advancements will underpin resilient, coordinated, and trustworthy AI planning in complex, unpredictable scenarios.

Expected Outcomes

Ambitious proposals put forward under this call will deliver:

- ✦ Models and/or architectures that handle multimodal data and knowledge, uncertainty, and can be trained and deployed with constrained computational resources
- ✦ Provable trustworthiness mechanisms ensuring explainability, transparency, fairness, risk evaluation, security and alignment with ethical and legal standards, including fundamental rights and the EU AI Act, and
- ✦ Demonstrate the developed capabilities integrated in a cognitive AI system (reaching TRL4) performing complex real-world tasks (e.g., scientific discovery, decision support, problem solving) as well as simulations at a scale.

In addition, proposals will:

- ✦ Propose new methods and metrics for evaluating and certifying reasoning and trustworthiness in AI as well as the use of the computational resources
- ✦ Follow the FAIR principles ensuring all data, models, and results are Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Reusable to maximise transparency, reproducibility, and impact, and
- ✦ Develop synergies with EU initiatives such as TEFs (AI Testing and Experimentation Facilities)⁵⁵, eBrains⁵⁶, Resource for AI Science in Europe (RAISE)⁵⁷, AI-on-demand Platform (AloD)⁵⁸ and the Quantum Flagship⁵⁹.

Portfolio approach

⁵⁵ [Sectorial AI Testing and Experimentation Facilities under the Digital Europe Programme | Shaping Europe's digital future](#)

⁵⁶ [EBRAINS: Europe's Research Infrastructure for Brain Research - EBRAINS](#)

⁵⁷ [Researchers and innovators invited to shape Europe's AI Strategy in Science | Shaping Europe's digital future](#)

⁵⁸ [Home Page | AI-on-Demand](#)

⁵⁹ [Introduction to the Quantum Flagship | Quantum Flagship](#)

The composition of the portfolio of projects to be funded under the DeepRAP Challenge will ensure comprehensive coverage across the following categories with a view to ensuring breadth and enabling synergies between the projects:

- ✦ Category 1 – Cognitive Function Capability: Reasoning, abstraction, and planning should be covered by the selected portfolio.
- ✦ Category 2 – Technological Approach: The selected projects are expected to use a variety of technological approaches, including but not limited to, neuro-symbolic AI, deep learning, reinforcement learning, and novel frameworks inspired by interdisciplinary fields, and
- ✦ Category 3 – Use Case and Application Domain: The selected projects will cover a variety of real-world domains, such as industry, mobility, civil security, scientific discovery, health, cybersecurity, justice and human-robot interaction.

The selected projects will also be assigned to lead and/or engage in portfolio activities centred on the following priorities:

- ✦ Interoperability: Establishing common standards and protocols to ensure seamless alignment between projects
- ✦ Benchmark Development: Co-creating a DeepRAP benchmark with shared tasks and an open evaluation platform for transparent assessment
- ✦ Common Pilots: Delivering joint pilot demonstrations addressing complex real-world problems to showcase DeepRAP capabilities
- ✦ Multiagent Integration: where feasible, combining project outcomes into modular, multiagent AI systems demonstrating collective reasoning and planning through structured interactions among multiple agents
- ✦ Application Shaping: Defining impactful use cases and engaging stakeholders to guide the development and adoption of innovative cognitive AI systems, and
- ✦ Ethical and Societal Alignment: Proactively addressing ethical, legal, and societal considerations, including fundamental rights, transparency, privacy, safety, and fairness of cognitive AI systems.

Expected Impact

The resulting portfolio will not only advance the scientific state-of-the-art but also build a robust, interoperable, and application-driven community, positioning Europe at the forefront of trustworthy cognitive AI. It should also lay the foundations for future European leadership in safe, human-centric cognitive AI, supporting sovereignty and competitiveness in key sectors. It will support the ambitions of the AI Act⁶⁰ and the European approach to Artificial Intelligence⁶¹.

⁶⁰<https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/news/commission-launches-ai-innovation-package-support-artificial-intelligence-startups-and-smes>

⁶¹ https://ec.europa.eu/commission/presscorner/detail/en/ip_24_383 150 AI Act | Shaping Europe's digital future (europa.eu)

VI. EIC Strategic Technologies for Europe Platform (STEP) Scale Up Call¹⁶⁹

- ❖ Does your company have a game-changing innovative technology focused on the development and commercialisation of a **strategic technology** for Europe in digital and deep tech, cleantech or biotech?
- ❖ Has your company already secured an **initial investment**, and is now looking to raise a major funding round to **scale up rapidly** and become a **global leader**?
- ❖ Does the successful commercialisation and scaling of your technology/ innovation **represent significant risks** which mean that it cannot be sufficiently financed from the market investors?

If you answered **yes** to all questions, then the EIC Strategic Technology for Europe Platform (STEP) Scale Up call could be your launchpad to success. This call provides significant funding to fuel groundbreaking innovation in **strategic technologies**¹⁷⁰, propelling Europe's economic, industrial, and technological competitiveness. This is a new call that has been introduced as a pilot action following the STEP Regulation¹⁷¹ to address an important market gap in financing deep tech scale up companies in Europe and to inform decisions on future support.

Why should you apply?

The EIC STEP Scale Up call presents a unique opportunity for ambitious scale up companies (SMEs and small mid-caps) with game-changing innovations **in Europe's critical technology areas**. It offers a powerful combination of financial and strategic support designed to propel your groundbreaking solution to the forefront of these sectors.

The companies selected under the EIC STEP Scale Up call shall receive **investments ranging from EUR 10 to EUR 30 million**. This investment can significantly accelerate the development and market launch of your technology, product, or service. With this funding, you'll gain the power to disrupt established markets and forge new ones across Europe, potentially achieving significant global impact. Crucially, this investment

¹⁶⁹ EIC STEP Scale Up call is a specific call as part of the EIC Accelerator as defined under Article 48 of the Horizon Europe Regulation - 2021/695 - EN - EUR-Lex (europa.eu) following its amendment by Article 17(2) of the STEP Regulation . The same provisions on indirect management and on parent and holding companies as set out under the Accelerator call apply.

¹⁷⁰ Guidance Note concerning certain provisions of Regulation (EU) 2024/795 establishing the Strategic Technologies for Europe Platform (STEP)

¹⁷¹ Strategic Technologies for Europe Platform (STEP), and amending Directive 2003/87/EC and Regulations (EU) 2021/1058, (EU) 2021/1056, (EU) 2021/1057, (EU) No 1303/2013, (EU) No 223/2014, (EU) 2021/1060, (EU) 2021/523, (EU) 2021/695, (EU) 2021/697 and (EU) 2021/241, OJ L, 2024/795, 29.2.2024, ELI: <http://data.europa.eu/eli/reg/2024/795/oj>.

is designed to **catalyse major funding rounds** in the range of EUR 50 to 150 million, and at least 3-5 times the EIC investment.

This call is part of the implementation of the Strategic Technologies for Europe Platform (STEP))¹⁷² which supports the development or manufacturing of critical technologies throughout the Union or safeguarding and strengthening their respective value chains. Besides, support from the EIC, the projects may be eligible for support under other EU programmes included in STEP.

In 2026 support for start-ups in semiconductor technologies and quantum technologies will be pursued in particular through the STEP Scale Up call which foresees larger investments targeting strategic technologies including in support of the Chips Act. The EIC Accelerator Open call remains available in general for startups and SMEs including for quantum and semiconductor technologies.

Can you apply?

In order to apply, your innovation must be within the scope of the priority sectors defined in the STEP regulation¹⁷³, which includes Critical Raw Materials, and further developed in the Guidance note¹⁷⁴

- a. **Digital technologies**¹⁷⁵, and deep tech innovations. This includes: advanced semiconductor technologies; artificial intelligence technologies; quantum technologies; advanced connectivity, navigation and digital technologies; advanced sensing technologies; robotics and autonomous systems; Deep tech innovations (see Glossary).
- b. **Clean and resource efficient technologies**, including net-zero technologies. This includes: solar technologies; onshore wind and offshore renewable technologies; energy storage technologies; heat pumps and geothermal technologies; hydrogen technologies; sustainable biogas and biomethane technologies; carbon capture and storage technologies; electricity grid technologies; nuclear fission technologies, sustainable alternative fuel technologies; hydropower technologies; other renewable technologies; energy system -related energy efficiency technologies; renewable fuels of nonbiological origin technologies; biotech climate and energy solutions; transformative industrial technologies for decarbonisation; CO2 transport and utilisation technologies; wind and electric propulsion technologies; other nuclear

¹⁷² https://strategic-technologies.europa.eu/index_en

¹⁷³ Regulation - EU - 2024/795 - EN - EUR-Lex (europa.eu), Article 2(1), point (a) of the STEP Regulation

¹⁷⁴ Guidance Note concerning certain provisions of Regulation (EU) 2024/795 establishing the Strategic Technologies for Europe Platform (STEP). C(2025)3148 of 8 May 2024.

¹⁷⁵ Including those contributing to the targets and objectives of the Digital Decade Policy Programme 2030, multi-country projects as defined in Article 2(2) of Decision (EU) 2022/2481

technologies; advanced materials¹⁷⁶, manufacturing and recycling technologies, technologies vital to sustainability such as water purification and desalination; and circular economy technologies.

- c. **Biotechnologies**, including medicinal products on the Union list of critical medicines and their components. Including DNA/RNA; proteins and other molecules; cell and tissue culture and engineering; process biotechnology techniques; Gene and RNA vectors; bioinformatics; and nanobiotechnology.

These technologies are deemed critical where they meet either of the following conditions:

- a. they bring to the internal market an innovative, emerging and cutting-edge element with significant economic potential;
- b. they contribute to reducing or preventing strategic dependencies of the Union.

The Commission [Guidance Note](#), concerning certain provisions of STEP Regulation adopted on May 2024, provides detailed information on the criticality conditions.

This call targets companies raising significant funding rounds and you must demonstrate an initial market interest such that the EIC investment acts as a catalyst for larger funding rounds.

You will therefore need to demonstrate that the company **already has a precommitment**¹⁷⁷ for an equity investment which meets the following elements:

- ❖ The pre-commitment comes from a single qualified investor¹⁷⁸ with demonstrable know-how and experience in the relevant market, technology and jurisdiction and subject to KYC by the EIC Fund or the EIF.¹⁷⁹ The pre-committed investor may be an existing investor in the company and does not necessarily need to be the investor who intends to lead the investment round.
- ❖ The pre-commitment represents at least 20% of the total target funding round you are aiming to raise.

The following entities are eligible to apply:

- ❖ A single company classified as a SME or small mid-cap (up to 499 employees) established within a Member State or an Associated Country (see Annex 2).

¹⁷⁶ According to the guidance note, this includes critical raw materials

¹⁷⁷ The pre-commitment is non-legally binding in nature and will be assessed at the time of proposal evaluation.

¹⁷⁸ Qualified Investor is an investor — public or private — with demonstrable know-how and experience in the relevant market, technology and jurisdiction, and which has been subject to KYC/AML screening and not considered high-risk. In case of high risk, such an investor can be exceptionally considered qualified if duly justified to protect against risks to economic security

¹⁷⁹ Investors who have not undergone a KYC by the EIC Fund or EIF may also provide pre-commitments, but this will be subject to the completion of a KYC during the eligibility checks.

The company may have a holding entity for the purposes of the investment, and this holding company must also be established in a Member State or an Associated Country.

- ❖ An investor may submit a proposal on behalf of an eligible SME or small midcap as defined above, provided that a prior agreement exists with the company. The investment agreement will be signed with the selected SME or small mid-cap.

The applicable admissibility and eligibility conditions are detailed in Annex 2 unless otherwise stated in this call. Furthermore, in case of investment support, specific safeguards may be introduced in the investment agreement (see Introduction, section on Economic Security).

Concurrent submissions to both the EIC Accelerator and EIC STEP Scale Up calls are not permitted; in the event of multiple submissions, only the proposal submitted most recently will be evaluated, and it will be assessed according to the merits and evaluation criteria of its respective call (Accelerator or STEP).

What support will you receive if your proposal is funded?

The EIC STEP Scale Up call offers a total indicative budget of EUR 300 million for 2026, which is expected to rise to EUR 900 million for the period 2025-2027¹⁸⁰. Any unused amount from this budget will be allocated with priority to the EIC Accelerator Open call.¹⁸¹

The support will be in the form of **equity-only investments** managed by the EIC Fund. Applicants to this call will not receive a grant component. It provides significant financial support, and applicants should apply for an **investment of a minimum of EUR 10 million¹⁸² and maximum of EUR 30 million**, to co-invest in a funding round¹⁸³ in the range of EUR 50 to 150 million, and at least three to five times the amount of the requested EIC contribution. The specific terms of each investment are considered and negotiated on a case-by-case basis in accordance with the EIC Fund Investment Guidelines. This ensures the investment is tailored to your company's needs while aligning with EIC's objectives.

EIC STEP Scale Up is designed to fill the funding gap for companies to invest in the scale up of high-risk innovations and where the amount needed for the scale up cannot

¹⁸⁰ This includes the EUR 300 million allocated under the EIC 2025 Work Programme and which may be reused in this call if there are unused amounts.

¹⁸¹ If applicants have been selected for funding under the Accelerator Open call. Otherwise, any remaining amounts may be allocated to other calls within the general flexibility of the Work Programme.

¹⁸² Applicants wishing to apply for lower investment amounts may apply to the EIC Accelerator call.

¹⁸³ The EIC Fund may join the round when relevant ongoing/upcoming /past.

be fully financed by other investors, including InvestEU direct and indirect financial products provided by implementing partners. Applicants are encouraged to consider in particular complementarity with Venture Debt from InvestEU implementing partners in order to meet their financing needs.

When implementing investments, the EIC Fund will ensure that supported companies keep most of their value, including their IP, in the EU or in the Associated Countries in order to contribute to their economic growth and job creation. Where necessary, the EIC Fund will be requested to take appropriate safeguard measures for individual companies on a case-by-case basis in order to protect European interests as defined in the Investment Guidelines.

Beyond funding, your company will benefit from a strong support system that fosters your continued growth within Europe through Business Acceleration Services (details available in Section VII). Applicants to the EIC STEP Scale Up call who meet the evaluation thresholds will also be **awarded a Sovereignty (STEP) Seal**, to facilitate and provide possibility of the access to funding and support from other EU programmes and other funders and investors.

How do you apply; how long does it take?

You may submit an application to the EIC STEP Scale Up call at any time. The evaluations of applications submitted will be organised with one batch per quarter (11/02/2026; 06/05/2026; 09/09/2026; 25/11/2026)¹⁸⁴. You must submit your proposal via the Funding and Tenders Portal.

1. Submission of proposals

To be deemed admissible and eligible, proposals must consist of:

- ❖ a full business plan, including information on the company's ownership and financial structure and a justification on the STEP related objectives (maximum 50 pages);
- ❖ a pitch-deck (maximum 15 pages) in pdf format (this version will be presented to the jury if invited to interview);
- ❖ a pre-commitment from a single qualified investor (according to the official template on the Funding and Tenders Portal and also available on the EIC website); The pre-commitment must represent at least 20% of the total target funding round, which must range between EUR 50 to 150 million, and be at least 3-5 times the EIC investment);

¹⁸⁴ Proposals will be batched at 17h00 Brussels time.

- ❖ a financial plan and agreement document (according to the template available on the EIC website).
- ❖ Results of the freedom to operate (FTO) analysis. If you do not have one, please upload a note of maximum 2 pages outlining your freedom to operate and providing as much information as possible on this issue. In cases where the FTO is not relevant (e.g. software), please upload a simple statement.
- ❖ CVs of key personnel

All personal data and information in your proposal will be kept strictly confidential. However, before submitting your full proposal, you will need to give agreement to share necessary information with the EIC Fund.

In addition, you will be asked as part of your application whether your company would be interested in Venture Debt support from InvestEU implementing partners, if your company is awarded a Sovereignty (STEP) Seal ¹⁸⁵.

Upon submission, your proposal will be assessed if it meets the eligibility criteria set out above in terms of whether it falls within scope of the STEP technologies; the pre-commitment from a single investor; and the eligibility of the applicant entity.

The investment adviser to the EIC Fund, may be requested to support the eligibility assessment regarding the pre-commitment from an investor.

In cases where a Technology Due Diligence report is not already available, this will be conducted by a suitably qualified external expert.

If your application meets these requirements, you will be invited to attend a jury interview. It is expected that you will be informed about the interview within approximately 4-6 weeks from the start of the evaluation process following the relevant batching date.

2. Interviews with an EIC Jury

At the interview, you will be assessed by a Jury of maximum six members (see Glossary). Detailed information about the format of the interview will be communicated to you in the invitation.

You will be informed about the result of the interview within approximately two weeks from the end of the interview session.

An award decision will be adopted by the Commission, which will authorise a maximum amount of investment by the EIC Fund, which will follow the amount requested in the application, with an additional flexibility amount of maximum EUR 5 million per

¹⁸⁵ InvestEU Implementing partners - European Union (europa.eu)

proposal. The flexibility amount is to enable the EIC Fund to make an investment decision for a higher amount than requested if justified to take account of developments of the company since the date of application and the opportunity of catalysing a larger overall funding round with co-investors. The additional flexibility amount may only be used if there are sufficient amounts available on the EIC Fund accounts (e.g., due to budget available from other investments).

The relevant information from your proposal will be passed to the investment adviser for the EIC Fund, to proceed with the detailed due diligence and subject to a positive due diligence and subsequent EIC Fund Investment Committee decision, the investment agreement. Should the investment due diligence result in a lower investment amount the released amount will be made available for additional funding under the EIC STEP Scale up call.

If you have expressed an interest and given agreement and your company has been awarded a Sovereignty (STEP) Seal following the evaluation, the relevant information from your proposal will be passed to the relevant InvestEU implementing partners to consider for Venture Debt support.

How does the EIC decide if your proposal will be selected for a potential investment by the EIC Fund?

Your proposal will be assessed on its merits by leading experts and the Commission will ensure open and fair competition to all eligible proposals submitted.

The EIC STEP Scale Up call utilizes a "first come, first served" approach to evaluate proposals. However, juries will be asked to take account of overall budget availability for the full year and will be limited to recommend proposals amounting to no more than 70% of the available budget for the calendar year within the first six months of the year. The Jury will be informed about budget availability, including additional amounts that may be available due to previous amounts awarded that were not fully used.

Proposals will be assessed according to the following award criteria (Table 8). The EIC Jury may focus the interview on any element of your proposal based on its own assessment.

The EIC Jury members, based on your interview and their overall assessment, will recommend one of three outcomes for your proposal:

❖ GO and Sovereignty (STEP) Seal:

Your proposal meets all of the evaluation criteria (see below) and is recommended for a potential equity investment. The Jury may provide observations for consideration by

the EIC Fund regarding the investment amount or other considerations for the investment decision or management. The Jury may recommend a different investment amount than requested by the applicant in line with the call's requirements. It is important to remember that investment amounts authorised in the Commission Award Decision are subject to successful completion of the due diligence and negotiation by the EIC Fund according to the Investment Guidelines, and investment amounts may be reduced or rejected by the EIC Fund for justified reasons.

Your project will also be awarded the Sovereignty (STEP) Seal and will have access to Business Acceleration Services.

❖ **NO GO and Sovereignty (STEP) Seal:**

Your proposal meets the main elements of the award criteria, including the contribution to the STEP objectives, but is not recommended for funding based on the jury's overall consideration of the submitted proposals and due to the lack of budget availability.

Your project will be awarded the Sovereignty (STEP) Seal and access to Business Acceleration Services.

❖ **NO GO:**

Your proposal does not meet all the evaluation criteria required for funding. You will receive detailed feedback outlining the areas where your proposal fell short to help you improve for future applications.

The Jury may also provide recommendations regarding a potential resubmission, or not, of your application and improvements needed.

Table 9. Award criteria elements for EIC STEP Scale Up proposals	
Excellence	
Innovation – Deep tech and breakthrough nature:	Is the proposed innovation deep tech in nature stemming from cutting-edge scientific or technological advances? Does it represent a significant improvement in cost or performance compared to existing or alternative solutions?
Technological feasibility:	Has the technology been developed in a safe, secure and reliable manner? Has it been adequately assessed, validated or certified?
Intellectual Property:	Does the innovation have adequate IP protection and sound IP strategy to enter the market to be addressed?
Impact	

<u>Market opportunity:</u> What and how big is the market addressed? What is the realistic expectation of the share of the total market?
<u>Business model:</u> Are the detailed business model and revenue strategy sound? Are the financial projections realistic?
<u>STEP Impact:</u> Does the innovation have a clear and measurable positive impact either by: Bringing to the Union's internal market an innovative, emerging and current-edge innovation with significant economic potential; or reducing or preventing strategic dependencies of the Union. (Note: applicants from Associated Countries will need to demonstrate contributions to the EU internal market or strategic dependencies)
Level of risk, implementation, and need for Union support
<u>Team capability:</u> Does the company have the necessary team in terms of skills and competences to develop the innovation and scale the company? Does the company have adequate governance and is the team sufficiently incentivised? Have any skills/competence gaps been identified, including adequate gender balance, with a credible plan to fill the gaps?
<u>Risk level of the investment:</u> Does the nature and level of risk of the investment in your innovation mean that European market actors are unwilling to commit the full amount that is needed without an investment from the EIC Fund?
<u>Investment leverage:</u> Does the proposal provide a convincing and realistic plan for raising an equity financing round using the EIC Fund investment to attract 3-5 times the amount from other investors? What is the anticipated timeline for concluding the financing round? How many investors have committed or are engaged in advanced discussions? How pressing is the timeline for finalising this deal?
<u>Risk management:</u> Have the main risks (e.g., technological, market, financial, regulatory) been comprehensively identified, together with measures to take to mitigate them?

Application submission limits

The EIC STEP Scale Up call applies limitations on the number of unsuccessful submissions of the same/improved proposal by the same legal entity.

As from 1 January 2026, after **three** unsuccessful submissions of the same/improved proposal by the same legal entity to the EIC STEP Scale Up call which can be at any stage of the process (eligibility check, interviews), an applicant may not apply again to the EIC STEP Scale Up call under the Horizon Europe Framework Programme.

In all cases, applicants are expected to take into account the feedback on their previous submission and only reapply if they have made significant improvements.